CHAPTER 6

Friday: Code That Writes Code

So far you've seen many wonderful metaprogramming spells—but it's possible that the meaning of the "m" word has only become fuzzier for you. The fact is, the original definition of metaprogramming as "writing code that writes code" doesn't fit every technique described in this book.

Rather than look for an updated, Wikipedia-worthy definition, we can accept that metaprogramming is not a single approach that you can define in a short sentence. It's more like a heterogeneous bag of tricks that all happen to revolve around the Ruby object model. And like any other bag of tricks, metaprogramming really comes into its own when you start blending many of those tricks together.

Today you'll learn a few new tricks you can add to that bag, including one that quite literally "writes code." But even better, you'll see how you can seamlessly mix and match many tricks to solve a difficult coding challenge.

Coding Your Way to the Weekend

Where your boss challenges you and Bill to write better code than she can.

After such an eventful week, you're looking forward to a relaxing Friday. But as soon as you sit down with Bill and your cup of coffee, your boss appears.

"You guys did a good job this week," she says. "Looking over your code, I got so excited about metaprogramming that I decided to learn it myself. But last night I got stuck on a difficult coding problem. Can you help me?"

Having a boss who used to be a programmer and still likes to get her hands dirty can sometimes make your life harder. But you're new at this job, and you can't say no when your boss is asking for your help.